

THE BUSINESS MATURITY MODEL

Stage 2

Traction

You're making sales. The problem is they come in fits and starts, and a slow week means you're back to hunting for the next one.

YOU + VENDORS · \$100K TO \$500K REVENUE

You are here.

Every business climbs the same ten stages, set by how many people you've got and how much you make. You're at **Traction**. Here's what that means, across your whole business.

0	Foundation	Just you · Pre-revenue
1	Validation	Just you · Under \$100K
2	Traction YOU ARE HERE	You + vendors · \$100K-\$500K
3	Structure	2-4 people · \$500K-\$1M
4	Focus	5-9 people · \$1M-\$3M
5	Expansion	10-19 people · \$3M-\$10M
6	Efficiency	20-49 people · \$10M-\$30M
7	Systems	50-99 people · \$30M-\$75M
8	Division	100-249 people · \$75M-\$150M
9	Reinvention	250-500 people · \$150M+

Stage 2: Traction

WHO

It's you, plus a freelancer or two when the work piles up. Nobody on payroll yet.

THE CONSTRAINT

Customers come in waves. Some weeks the phone won't stop, then it goes quiet and you're hunting again.

GRADUATE BY

Do the work that brings customers in every day, busy or slow.

THE BIG PICTURE

The first stages were about proving the thing works. You found a problem worth solving, made something people would pay for, and got the first dollars in the door. That part's behind you. People buy what you sell, and they come back. Now a different problem shows up. The sales are coming in, but they're streaky, and the whole business moves with them.

Here's the trap almost everyone falls into at this stage. You hustle when work is thin, land a few customers, then go heads-down delivering and stop reaching out. A few weeks later the pipeline's empty and you're scrambling again. The feast-or-famine cycle is the predictable result of starting and stopping the work that brings customers in.

Working in bursts won't get you out of this. The businesses that break through do the same handful of things every single day, whether they're slammed or slow, and they make each piece repeatable instead of reinventing it every time. Here's what that looks like across every part of your business.

This stage comes down to one habit: doing the work that brings customers in every day, and making it repeatable enough to hand off later. The next pages run that habit across all three engines of your business.

Across your business.

Every business runs on three engines. Eight parts sit inside them. At Traction, one part is breaking each engine right now. Those three are marked Start here. Fix them and the rest steadies.

SALES & MARKETING

Marketing

START HERE

Your lead flow turns on and off with your week. You market hard when you're hungry, stop the day you're full, and the pipeline dries up right behind you. *social proof · Influence honest scarcity · Influence*

Sales

START HERE

Your closing is hit or miss. You wing each conversation, so you can't tell why one prospect buys and the next one walks. *the documented sales methodology · The Sales Acceleration Formula coach one stage off the funnel · The Sales Acceleration Formula*

Customer service

Paying customers expect more than the free ones did, and a few are starting to complain.

Technology

You've got no budget for tools and everything lives in your head or a notebook.

OPERATIONS

Product & service

START HERE

Paying customers want it done right and the same way twice, and right now the way it gets done is whatever you remember to do. It's all in your head, so it changes every time. *document the core process (the 20/80 rule) · Traction*

Customer service (delivery)

You're the only one who knows how anything gets done.

Technology (ops)

You're tempted to buy software to fix the mess.

FINANCE & ADMIN

Finance

You don't track the money or what you'll owe in taxes, so you run the business off yesterday's deposits.

Hiring

The work's getting heavy for part-timers and freelancers, but you can't carry a full payroll yet.

Your people

You're treating contractors like employees, which is a legal problem waiting to bite you.

Start here.

The one part breaking each engine. Get these right and the rest of the stage gets easier. Each names the tell, what to do, and the book behind it.

Marketing SALES & MARKETING

You only reach out when work gets slow, then go quiet the second it's busy.

THE CONSTRAINT

Your lead flow turns on and off with your week. You market hard when you're hungry, stop the day you're full, and the pipeline dries up right behind you.

DO THIS

Pick a small number of moves that bring customers in, then do them every day no matter how busy you are. The number matters more than the cleverness. While you're at it, put your proof to work: show that other people like them buy from you and trust you, because a buyer who's unsure reads the crowd before they read your pitch. If a spot or a slot is genuinely limited, say so plainly. Never fake it. That gets found out and it costs you.

SOURCE social proof · *Influence*, Robert Cialdini

SOURCE honest scarcity · *Influence*, Robert Cialdini

Sales SALES & MARKETING

Two prospects get two different pitches because it's all in your head.

THE CONSTRAINT

Your closing is hit or miss. You wing each conversation, so you can't tell why one prospect buys and the next one walks.

DO THIS

Write down one way you sell and run it every time. Map how your customer buys, build your steps to match it, and pin down the few things you need to learn before you know you can help them. Name each step so you could check it later. Once it's written, watch your numbers stage by stage and fix the one spot where you keep losing people, instead of changing everything at once.

SOURCE the documented sales methodology · *The Sales Acceleration Formula*, Mark Roberge

SOURCE coach one stage off the funnel · *The Sales Acceleration Formula*, Mark Roberge

Product & service OPERATIONS

Two customers buy the same thing and get two different versions of it.

THE CONSTRAINT

Paying customers want it done right and the same way twice, and right now the way it gets done is whatever you remember to do. It's all in your head, so it changes every time.

DO THIS

Write down how you deliver, the core handful of steps, at a high level. Capture the 20% of the work that drives 80% of the result and stop there, no 500-page manual. Documenting it does two things: it makes the work come out the same every time, and it's the first step toward handing pieces of it to someone else so you stop being the only one who can do it.

SOURCE document the core process (the 20/80 rule) · *Traction*, Gino Wickman

The rest of your business.

Not the three to start with, but they're in play at this stage. Here's the move on each, for when you're ready.

SALES & MARKETING

Customer service

Paying customers expect more than the free ones did, and a few are starting to complain.

DO THIS

Have a simple way to handle an unhappy customer: hear them out, fix it fast, follow up. The ones you save become the proof that sells the next deal, so ask your happy customers for a few words you can show.

Technology

You've got no budget for tools and everything lives in your head or a notebook.

DO THIS

Use the free tier of everything. A simple site that captures a lead, a starter CRM so nobody falls through the cracks, a shared calendar. Nothing fancy yet, just somewhere the work lives besides your memory.

OPERATIONS

Customer service (delivery)

You're the only one who knows how anything gets done.

DO THIS

Turn the steps you just wrote into a short checklist. A checklist makes the work hard to botch and lets a freelancer pick up a piece without you walking them through it every time.

Technology (ops)

You're tempted to buy software to fix the mess.

DO THIS

Don't pay for the fancy tool yet. A cheap off-the-shelf product almost always beats custom-built at this size. Pick the tech that fits how you work and bend it to your process.

FINANCE & ADMIN

Finance

You don't track the money or what you'll owe in taxes, so you run the business off yesterday's deposits.

DO THIS

Spin up bookkeeping so you can see what comes in and goes out. Set money aside for quarterly taxes, and get a straight CPA to tell you how much. Run the business off the books, where the full picture lives.

Hiring

The work's getting heavy for part-timers and freelancers, but you can't carry a full payroll yet.

DO THIS

Lean on freelancers for the overflow for now. Start writing down what each task takes, so when you can afford your first full-time hire, you know what you're hiring for.

Your people

You're treating contractors like employees, which is a legal problem waiting to bite you.

DO THIS

Keep the line clean. A contractor sets their own hours and uses their own tools. When someone starts looking like an employee, make them one the right way. Don't blur it to save paperwork.

Where you stand.

ON TRACK

- You do the same customer-getting work every day, busy or slow
- You sell the same way each time and know your numbers stage by stage
- Your delivery is written down where anyone could follow it
- You've got happy customers willing to vouch for you
- Your books are clean and tax money is set aside

STILL NEED WORK

- You only market when work gets thin
- You couldn't say why one prospect bought and the next didn't
- Every job gets done a little differently
- You're the only person who knows how anything works
- You run the business off yesterday's deposits

Graduating to Stage 3. You'll know you're ready when the sales stop swinging. Steady customers come in every week, you've got a way of selling and delivering you could teach someone, and the load is heavy enough that you're ready to bring on your first full-time help. The next stage is about making your first hires and getting work off your own plate.

Want the next stage before you hit it?

The one move that changes the most here is picking a few customer-getting actions and doing them every single day, busy or slow. I send a short weekly note on this kind of thing. Get on the list and I'll help you build the business behind the sales.

BUILT ON

This stage draws on **Influence** (Robert Cialdini), **The Sales Acceleration Formula** (Mark Roberge), and **Traction** (Gino Wickman). The moves are ours. The thinking stands on theirs.